Edd K. Usman

Edmund "Edd" K. Usman is a veteran Filipino Muslim journalist whose career spans several decades of award-winning reporting in science, technology, and Muslim affairs.

He is best known nationally as a longtime senior correspondent for the Manila Bulletin (https://mb.com.ph), one of the Philippines' oldest and most widely read broadsheets, where he covered the Department of Science and Technology (https://dost.gov.ph) (DOST), the Philippine Charity Sweepstakes Office (https://pcso.gov.ph) (PCSO), and Muslim community affairs, among other beats.

His journalism has always aimed at bridging worlds that might otherwise seem far apart: the world of rockets and microsatellites, and the world of faith, peace, and Bangsamoro identity.

In 2018, Usman made history as the first-ever winner of the **Best Science Feature Story for Print and Online** award at the inaugural UP Science Journalism Awards, held at the University of the Philippines Diliman (https://upda.edu.ph).<ref name="UP2018">University of the Philippines. (2018, February 19). "UP honors top science journalists." Retrieved from https://up.edu.ph/up-honors-top-science-journalists/</ref>

The winning entry, published through Rappler, explored the engineering improvements of the Philippines' second microsatellite, Diwata-2, over its predecessor, Diwata-1.<ref name="Rappler2018">Rappler. (2018, February 18). "Rappler wins best science feature story at 1st UP Science Journalism Awards." Retrieved from https://www.rappler.com/about/196309-rappler-up-science-journalism-awards-best-science-feature-story/</ref>

That recognition cemented his reputation not just as a beat reporter, but as someone who genuinely cared about helping ordinary Filipinos understand why science matters to their daily lives.

Edd K. Usman



Born	Edmund K. Usman
Nationality	Filipino
Occupation	Journalist, Science Writer, Digital News Publisher
Known for	First winner of the UP Science Journalism Award for Best Science Feature Story (2018); veteran science and Muslim affairs correspondent
Employer(s)	Manila Bulletin (until 2016); Rappler; SDN SciTech and Digital News (founder)
Awards	UP Science Journalism Award (2018); Kabalikat Award, PCIEERD-DOST (2014)
Website	SciTechandDigital.News (https://scitechanddigital.news)

Today, he continues his work as the founder and publisher of **SDN SciTech and Digital News** (scitechanddigital.news), an independent digital outlet that covers science, technology, and Muslim Filipino community affairs.

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Background

Usman's full given name is **Edmund**, though he has gone by "Edd" throughout his professional life, a pen name that became as familiar in newsrooms as it was on bylines.

His journalism reflects a dual identity that is deeply personal: he is both a seasoned national reporter with access to science ministries and satellite engineers, and a Muslim Filipino deeply attuned to the concerns of communities in Mindanao, Metro Manila's Muslim quarters, and the broader Bangsamoro diaspora.

While detailed public records about his early life, hometown, and family background are not extensively documented in available sources, his reporting consistently reflects a journalist shaped by both secular professional training and a lived understanding of Islam as practiced in the Philippine context.

His range of covered topics, from the mechanics of microsatellite orbits to the annual logistics of the Hajj pilgrimage for Filipino Muslims, suggests a reporter who moves naturally between the worlds of science and faith, and who sees no contradiction between the two.

Education

Specific details of Usman's formal academic education have not been extensively documented in publicly available records.

What is on record, however, is a consistent pattern of professional development through international training that shaped his capacity as a science and technology journalist.

In 2002, he participated in the **Executive Seminar for Information Technology Journalists** in South Korea, an early indicator of his specialization in technology reporting at a time when the internet was only beginning to reshape Philippine newsrooms.<ref name="WorldNgayon">WorldNgayon. "Edd K. Usman - Author Profile." Retrieved from https://worldngayon.com/author/edd-uzman/</ref>

In 2008, he was accepted as a fellow to the prestigious **East-West Center Senior Journalists Seminar** in the United States, a program run by the East-West Center in Honolulu, Hawaii, which brings together senior journalists from across Asia and the Pacific to deepen regional understanding and journalistic practice.<ref name="WorldNgayon"/>

These two international fellowships, separated by six years, trace the arc of a journalist who treated learning as an ongoing professional obligation, not a credential to collect and shelve.

Professional Career

Manila Bulletin Years

The anchor of Usman's professional career was his long tenure as a senior journalist at the **Manila Bulletin (https://mb.com.ph)**, a publication founded in 1900 and widely regarded as one of the country's most trusted broadsheets.<ref name="MBHistory">Manila Bulletin. "Our Company." Retrieved from https://mb.com.ph/our-company</ref>

He served the Bulletin for many years, covering a remarkably broad set of beats that ranged from police and crime to health, governance, and science policy.

His core institutional beats included the DOST, the PCSO, the TESDA, and Muslim affairs, a combination that placed him at intersections most reporters rarely occupied.<ref name="Rappler2016">Rappler. (2016, December 2). "DOST researchers win P1.3 million in total prizes for published studies." Retrieved from https://www.rappler.com/technology/154296-dost-researchers-published-studies-awards/</ref>

His tenure at the Bulletin ended on April 15, 2016, after which he transitioned fully into freelance and independent journalism.

Freelance and Contributor Work

After leaving the Bulletin, Usman remained prolific. He contributed work to several major and niche platforms, including Rappler, Newsbytes.ph, Claire Delfin Online Magazine, Malaya Business Insight, the Agriculture Magazine (a Manila Bulletin publication), and the U.S.-based Philippine News.<ref name="WorldNgayon"/>

He also contributed exclusive reports to the BusinessMirror, including coverage of the Palestinian diplomatic community in Manila in the context of the 2023 Gaza conflict and its impact on Filipino workers in Israel.<ref name="BizMirror2023">BusinessMirror. (2023, November 6). "Our hearts bleed for them: Palestinian envoy mourns Filipino victims in Gaza." Retrieved from https://businessmirror.com.ph/2023/11/06/our-hearts-bleed-for-them-palestinian-envoy-mourns-filipino-victims-in-gaza/</ref>

This kind of story, connecting Muslim Filipino concerns to global events through direct diplomatic sourcing, is very much Usman at his most characteristic: grounding international stories in local human stakes.

SDN SciTech and Digital News

Perhaps his most entrepreneurial step was launching his own independent digital news outlet, **SDN SciTech and Digital News** (scitechanddigital.news).

The platform covers science and technology news, BARMM governance, Muslim Filipino community affairs, national policy, and international stories relevant to Filipino Muslims.

His byline at SDN carries his social media handles: Twitter at @edd1819 and Instagram at @bluestar0910, reflecting a journalist who embraced digital distribution as comfortably as he once filed broadsheet copy.

Through SDN, Usman has reported on the BARMM, the NCMF, Metro Manila Muslim traders, and the recurring controversies surrounding the annual Hajj operations for Filipino pilgrims, stories that sit squarely at the intersection of governance and faith.<ref name="SDN2024">SDN SciTech and Digital News. (2024, March 8).

"DILG Secretary Benhur Abalos Designates Com. Michael Mamukid as NCMF Officer-in-Charge." Retrieved from https://scitechanddigital.news/2024/03/08/dilg-secretary-benhur-abalos-designates-com-michael-mamukid-as-ncmf-officer-in-charge/</ref>

Contributions to Science Journalism

The Diwata Satellite Coverage

If there is one body of work that defines Usman's legacy in Philippine science journalism, it's his sustained coverage of the Phil-Microsat program and, in particular, the Diwata satellite series.

His article for Rappler, published in June 2017, titled "How Diwata-2 is better than PH's first satellite, Diwata-1," brought readers inside the engineering decisions behind the country's second microsatellite with a clarity that few journalists achieved.<ref name="RapplerDiwata">Rappler. (2017, June 5). "How Diwata-2 is better than PH's first satellite, Diwata-1." Retrieved from https://www.rappler.com/technology/features/171988-diwata-1-diwata-2-improvements-up-tech-fair/</ref>

The article explained improvements such as the addition of a radio for better communication, a sun-synchronous orbit placed 213 kilometers higher than Diwata-1's, and the satellite's enhanced camera payload, all written in the kind of plain language that invited general readers in rather than shutting them out.

It was this article, submitted under his Rappler contributor byline, that won the inaugural UP Science Journalism Award in 2018.

It's also worth noting that Usman coined the collective nickname "**Magnificent 9**" for the nine pioneering Filipino engineers who designed and assembled Diwata-1, a moniker that stuck in Philippine science reporting and became part of how that milestone was remembered.<ref name="WorldNgayon2">WorldNgayon. "Diwata-2 Launched: DOST intensifies space program." Retrieved from https://worldngayon.com/diwata-2-launched-dost-intensifies-space-program/</ref>

That's the kind of contribution that goes beyond a single article. It shapes how a nation tells its own scientific story.

Bridging Faith and Technology

Beyond satellites, Usman has long explored the intersection of Islamic life and modern technology, asking questions like: How does the internet change the way Filipino Muslims practice their faith? How do digital systems reshape the Hajj experience for pilgrims from the Philippines?

These stories don't fit neatly into any single beat. They require a journalist with one foot in the science ministry and another in the mosque, and Usman has occupied that rare position throughout his career.

Advocacy for Science Communication

Usman has been a consistent voice for raising the standard of science reporting in the Philippines.

His win at the UP Science Journalism Awards, which were themselves created specifically to reward accuracy and accessibility in science reporting, placed him at the center of an emerging national conversation about what good science journalism looks like.<ref name="UP2018"/>

> "Very often, science is perceived to be something that is not understandable, something that exists in laboratories. Our program aims to highlight the fact that developments in science benefit everything we do and use." — Dr. Elena Pernia, UP CoST Program Leader, on the purpose of the UP Science Journalism Awards where Usman was first honored.<ref name="UPhonors">University of the Philippines. (2018, February 19). "UP honors top science journalists." Retrieved from https://up.edu.ph/up-honors-top-science-journalists/</ref>

The sentiment captures exactly what Usman has practiced throughout his career: the belief that science journalism is a public service, not just a technical exercise.

Awards and Recognition

Usman's awards track the specific commitments that have defined his career.

In **2014**, he won the **Print Media** category of the **Kabalikat Award**, part of the PCIEERD-DOST Science Journalism Awards given by the Philippine Council for Industry, Energy and Emerging Technology Research and Development (PCIEERD) under the DOST, in recognition of his contribution to promoting science and technology journalism in the Philippines.<ref name="WorldNgayon"/>

In **2018**, he became the **first-ever winner** of the **Best Science Feature Story for Print and Online** at the inaugural **UP Science Journalism Awards**, organized by the University of the Philippines College of Mass Communication and held at UP Diliman on February 17.<ref name="UP2018"/><ref name="Rappler2018"/>

The awards jury at UP included journalists, academicians, scientists, and an economist, reflecting the multidisciplinary standard against which his Diwata-2 feature was measured and found exemplary.<ref name="UPhonors"/>

These two awards, separated by four years, confirm a journalist who consistently performed at the highest level of a specialized field.

Cultural Significance

In the landscape of Philippine journalism, Usman represents something that's genuinely rare: a Muslim Filipino journalist working at a national broadsheet level, covering both hard science and Muslim community affairs with equal fluency.

His reporting on the ARMM and later the BARMM, on the Hajj, and on Muslim traders and community leaders in Metro Manila gives voice to a constituency that is too often absent from mainstream Philippine media, or present only in the context of conflict.

Through SDN, he continues to provide a platform where Bangsamoro governance, Muslim Filipino identity, and science and digital news coexist in a single editorial space, which is itself a statement about how broad and interconnected those concerns actually are.

His career models a form of journalism that sees no contradiction between faith and empirical inquiry, between community accountability and national science coverage.

Personal Values

Usman's body of work reflects a journalist driven by a few clear values.

The first is a commitment to **accuracy**, particularly in science reporting, where the gap between what researchers know and what the public understands can be wide enough to do real harm. His sustained focus on DOST and the Phil-Microsat program was never just about filing stories. It was about building public literacy.

The second is a commitment to **the Muslim Filipino perspective**, covering the Bangsamoro community not as an object of national policy but as a subject with its own voice, its own governance debates, and its own relationship to modernity and faith.

The third is **independence**. In founding SDN SciTech and Digital News, Usman chose the harder road of building his own platform rather than depending entirely on established outlets. For a veteran journalist of his standing, that's a choice that says something about where he thinks the work needs to happen.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Department of Science and Technology (Philippines)
- Diwata (satellite)
- Filipino Muslims
- Manila Bulletin
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Philippine space program
- Rappler
- UP Science Journalism Awards

Further Reading

- Usman, E. K. (2017, June 5). "How Diwata-2 is better than PH's first satellite, Diwata-1." Rappler. https://www.rappler.com/technology/features/171988-diwata-1-diwata-2-improvements-up-tech-fair/
- Usman, E. K. (2023, November 6). "Our hearts bleed for them: Palestinian envoy mourns Filipino victims in Gaza." BusinessMirror. https://businessmirror.com.ph/2023/11/06/our-hearts-bleed-for-them-palestinian-envoy-mourns-filipino-victims-in-gaza/
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- SDN SciTech and Digital News. https://scitechanddigital.news

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